



DOMESTIC VIOLENCE IN THE SUBCONTINENT

CULTURE, REALITY, AND SOLUTIONS

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Introduction

Domestic violence is a hidden epidemic that has haunted households across the Indian subcontinent (Pakistan and India). This socio-moral crisis continues to affect millions—if not billions—of individuals, regardless of their religion, caste, or class.

Unfortunately, this tradition of violence has flourished in silence, often rooted in irrational cultural norms, misinterpreted religious doctrines, and deeply entrenched patriarchal values. Thus, the purpose of this booklet is to break this silence.

We will explore the historical and cultural reasons that perpetuate this violence, detail its harmful effects, outline its various forms—whether perpetrated by husbands or wives—and finally, clarify the truth through authentic Islamic teachings: What was meant to be, and what have we become? When viewed through Islam's rational, natural, logical, and ethical principles, it becomes clear that domestic violence is sheer ignorance.

Our goal is to promote understanding, challenge harmful norms, guide individuals toward building relationships based on mutual respect, justice, and

compassion, and empower them
to resist oppression.

Chapter 1 – Historical Shadows and Cultural Chains

The Burden of History: From Sati to Silence

Our understanding of domestic violence in the subcontinent cannot be complete without acknowledging its historical context. Practices like Sati—the horrifying tradition where widows were expected (or forced) to immolate themselves on their husbands' funeral pyres—epitomize the historical devaluation of women's lives, binding their existence entirely to their husbands'. Although Sati is now

illegal, the underlying mindset that views women as secondary, insignificant, or disposable persists in modern social structures, cultural attitudes, and norms.

Language as a Weapon: Idioms Normalizing Violence

Culture shapes our daily realities, and language is its primary tool. In Urdu and Hindi, marital idioms are not mere phrases—they reinforce power imbalances and trivialize abusive behavior. Let us examine some unethical, inhumane, and un-Islamic idioms:

The Trap of Perpetual Oppression:

"Ḍolī meṇ āī ho, ab arthī/janāze par hī jāo gī."

(Literal: You came in a bridal palanquin; you will leave only on a funeral bier.)

Cultural Impact: Enforces the idea that marriage is absolute and permanent, implying death is the only escape. This mentality traps women in abusive marriages, contradicting Islam's mandate to oppose oppression.

"Ab tumhārā janāza hī is ghar se uṭhegā."

(Literal: Only your funeral bier will leave this house.)

Cultural Impact: A direct threat, normalizing lifelong entrapment in abusive households.

Sacrificing Women's Agency:

"Ṣabr karo/Bardāsht karo."

(Literal: Be patient/Endure.)

Cultural Impact: Romanticizes suffering as a virtue for women.

"‘Aurat ko hī ghar banānā partā hai.’"

(Literal: Only the woman must build the home.)

Cultural Impact: Places full responsibility for marital harmony on wives, blaming them for abuse.

Shame Over Sanctity:

"Log kyā kahenge?"

(Literal: What will people say?)

Cultural Impact: Prioritizes social reputation over safety and well-being.

"Nāk kaṭvānā."

(Literal: To have one's nose cut [i.e., humiliation].)

Cultural Impact: Stigmatizes divorce, especially when initiated by women.

Excusing Male Aggression:

"Mard hai, ghuṣṣā ā jātā hai."

(Literal: He's a man; anger comes naturally.)

Cultural Impact: Normalizes male violence as uncontrollable.

"Shohar majāzī Khudā hotā hai."

(Literal: The husband is a metaphorical God.)

Cultural Impact: Demands unconditional obedience to husbands, contradicting Islam's focus on divine authority and teachings alone.

Enforcing Silence:

"Ghar kī bāt ghar meṁ hī rahnī chāhiye."

(Literal: Family matters should stay within the house.)

Cultural Impact: Isolates victims and prevents intervention.

These idioms are harmful cultural chains that normalize violence, making it seem inevitable or justified.

Chapter 2 – The Wounds That Bind All: Impacts on Communities

Accepting these historical attitudes and culturally entrenched idioms has deep, harmful consequences for all subcontinental communities, regardless of religious background which leads to the following effects:

Normalizing Violence: Abuse becomes an expected, albeit unpleasant, part of marriage. **Children raised in such environments learn that violence is a tool for conflict resolution.**

Internalized Victimhood: Survivors believe oppressive narratives—that

they deserve abuse or have no escape.

Barriers to Help: Fear of stigma ("Log kyā kahenge?"), lack of familial support ("Nāḱ kaṭvānā"), systemic failures, and economic dependence trap victims.

Mental Health Crisis: Survivors suffer from depression, anxiety, PTSD, low self-esteem, and suicidal tendencies.

Physical Health Decline: Chronic stress leads to long-term ailments.

Erosion of Trust: Violence destroys the love (mawaddah) and mercy (raḥmah) central to Islamic marriage.

These effects permeate society,
creating a collective wound.

Chapter 3 – When Power Lies With the Husband: Violence by Men

As witnessed throughout history or currently in media extensively that patriarchal ideologies enable husbands to perpetrate violence in forms such as:

Physical Abuse: Beating, slapping, kicking, burning, choking, confinement.

Psychological Abuse: Constant criticism, humiliation (e.g., targeting appearance, intelligence, or cooking skills), threats (of violence, divorce, or harming family).

Verbal Abuse: Screaming, cursing, derogatory language.

Sexual Abuse: Coercion, forced pornography, reproductive control.

Economic Abuse: Controlling finances, blocking employment, withholding necessities.

Technological Abuse: Surveillance via phones, cyber harassment.

Cultural Abuse: Using traditions (e.g., dowry demands) to justify control.

Chapter 4 – When Power Lies With the Wife: Violence by Women

Though underreported due to stigma, wives also perpetrate violence, including:

Psychological Abuse: Emasculation (e.g., "Tum to mard jaisē nahīn ho"—You're not man enough), public humiliation, isolation from family.

Verbal Abuse: Taunts, curses, insults targeting the husband's family.

Economic Abuse: Extortion, salary control, debt manipulation.

Physical Abuse: Slapping, scratching, etc.

Legal Abuse: False police reports, custody battles.

Parental Alienation: Turning children against fathers.

Cultural Abuse: Encouraging in-laws to harass husbands.

Men face barriers to reporting due to shame, societal ridicule, and lack of support systems.

Chapter 5 – Toward True Guidance: The Islamic Perspective

Many harmful cultural norms directly contradict Islamic teachings:

Marriage as Sanctuary: The Qur'an (30:21) describes marriage as a source of tranquility (sakīnah), love (mawaddah), and mercy (raḥmah). Violence violates this foundation.

Condemning Oppression: The Prophet (pbuh said), "*A Muslim is one from whose tongue and hand others are safe.*"

Divorce as Relief: Islam permits divorce (ṭalāq, khu'l) to escape

harm, rejecting idioms like "janāza hī uṭhegā."

E m p o w e r m e n t T h r o u g h
Contracts: Marriage contracts (nikāḥ-nāmah) can grant wives conditional rights, including divorce.

Divine Justice: The Qur'an and Ahl al-Bayt (pbut) emphasize opposing oppression (ẓulm) and upholding amr bil-ma'rūf (enjoining good).

Healing and Hope

Domestic violence in the subcontinent is a complex issue rooted in regressive cultural and pseudo-religious norms.

Recognizing its forms, rejecting toxic idioms, and embracing Islam's ethical framework of justice ('adl), mercy (rahmah), and compassion can break this cycle.

Let us build families grounded in divine principles—not cultural ignorance—and empower survivors to reclaim their God-given dignity.

Final Note:

Change begins when we prioritize Qur'anic and Ahl al-Bayt's teachings over regressive customs. Only then can we heal.